CYBER SAFETY GUY

SNAPCHAT

THE BASICS PARENTS NEED TO KNOW

Snapchat is a photo and video messaging app where messages (Snaps) disappear after being viewed. It's fun and creative – but it also comes with risks. Here's what parents need to know.

800M+
monthly active Snapchat users worldwide
Snap Inc. (2024)

75%
of 13–34 year olds in the US use Snapchat
Pew Research (2023)

30+
minutes per day is the average time teens spend on Snapchat
DataReportal (2024)

TOP 3
app teens say they use most to stay in touch with friends
Pew Research (2023)

KEY FEATURES – WHAT MAKES SNAPCHAT DIFFERENT

SNAPS
Photos or videos that disappear after being viewed (1–10 seconds by default).

STORIES
Snaps that last 24 hours and can be viewed by friends or everyone (public story).

SNAP MAP
Shows your location on a map to friends who have location sharing on.

CHAT
Messages disappear by default after being viewed in chat.

STREAKS
You and a friend send Snaps back and forth for consecutive days to keep a Streak.

SPOTLIGHT
Public feed of user-submitted Snaps. Anyone can view, like and share.

SNAP SCORE
A score that goes up when you send/receive Snaps. Many teens focus on getting higher.

WHY KIDS LOVE SNAPCHAT

- It feels private and "in the moment"
- Fun filters, Lenses and creative tools
- Easy way to stay in touch with friends
- Streaks create connection and routine
- Stories and Spotlight help them express themselves



RISKS PARENTS SHOULD KNOW

- **Disappearing doesn't mean gone.** Screenshots, screen recordings and camera photos can save Snaps.
- **Strangers can contact your child.** Anyone can send a Chat or view a public Story/Spotlight.
- **Location sharing can expose them.** Snap Map can reveal where your child is – in real time.
- **Inappropriate content exists.** Spotlight and Stories can include sensitive or explicit content.
- **Pressure & comparison.** Streaks, Snap Score and filters can affect self-esteem.



SNAPCHAT PRIVACY: WHAT PARENTS CAN CONTROL

Who can contact them
Restrict to "Friends" so only accepted friends can message.

View My Story
Limit to "Friends" or "Custom" instead of "Everyone".

See My Location (Snap Map)
Choose "Ghost Mode" or "My Friends (except...)" for more privacy.

See Me in Quick Add
Turn off so your child isn't suggested to people they don't know.

Family Center
Connect with your teen to see their privacy settings and who they've friended (not content).



Check these settings together and review them regularly.

TIPS FOR PARENTS

- **Talk early and often.** Keep the conversation open and judgment-free.
- **Know their friends.** Help them understand who's safe to talk to.
- **Review privacy settings together.** Make them part of the process.
- **Be aware of Snap Map.** Talk about location sharing and safety.
- **Discuss what's not okay.** Set clear boundaries around content and behavior.
- **Encourage them to speak up.** If something feels off, tell a trusted adult.



RED FLAGS TO SPOT

- Love-bombing or over-the-top attention
- Asking for secrets or personal photos
- Moving to private chat quickly
- Pressure for streaks or replies
- Jealousy or control
- Threats or blackmail

CONVERSATION STARTERS

- Who do you like talking to online?
- What's fun about that game/app?"
- Has anyone ever made you feel weird or uncomfortable online?"
- What would you do if someone asked for a photo or a secret?'
- "I'm always here if something doesn't feel right."



SAFETY RULES THAT HELP

- Never share personal info (name, address, school or photos).
- Don't share or send nudes. It's unsafe, illegal and can't be taken back.
- Don't meet online friends. People can lie about who they are.
- Tell a trusted adult if something feels wrong, upsetting or confusing.
- Block and report. You don't have to respond.

QUICK DO'S & DON'TS

DO
- Encourage open conversations.
- Know their username and friends.
- Review privacy settings together.
- Praise good choices.
- Be a trusted place for help.

DON'T
- Spy or snoop.
- Overreact—listen first.
- Stereotype all online friends.
- Ignore problems.
- Blame or judge.

WHERE TO GET HELP

Childline
0800 1111
childline.org.uk

The Mix
0808 808 4994
themix.org.uk

Internet Matters
internetmatters.org
Advice, guides and tools for parents

REMEMBER

Your involvement today helps your child make safer choices tomorrow.

NEED TO TALK?
CHILDLINE 0800 1111

0800 1111
childline.org.uk

YOU ARE NOT ALONE We're here for you.